

How to Select the Right UTM Appliance for SMEs



With the rise of the cyber crooks in virtual space, a robust security solution has become a critical need for small and medium businesses. Unified Threat Management (UTM) appliances are meant to combat virtual intrusions and provide a security net to businesses.

The growing instances of complex, sophisticated virtual crimes can be a major threat to any business, irrespective of its size, and can impact its smooth functioning in a major way. Given that many small and medium enterprises have budgets for only a restricted number of IT staff members and limited security services, it's not surprising that the market for Unified Threat Management (UTM) appliances is growing steadily.

A UTM refers to a comprehensive security product that brings down virtual intrusion against numerous security threats. A UTM appliance is a single, cost-effective and easy-to-manage appliance that can be a better solution compared to various security software products running on separate servers. A UTM product typically includes a firewall, antivirus software, content filtering and a spam filter, all in a single cohesive package.

A UTM provides the following functionalities:

- Standard network firewall
- Remote access and site-to-site virtual private network (VPN) support
- Web security gateway functionality (anti-malware, as well as URL and content filtering)
- Network intrusion prevention focused on blocking attacks against PCs and servers

Besides the above, most UTMs provide other features like email security, Web application firewalls, and data loss prevention systems.

Key factors to be considered while buying a UTM appliance for your business

While looking for a robust UTM appliance in the market, the first thing you need to keep in mind is that it should fulfil and suit your specific requirements. That apart, factors like pricing and flexibility also play a key role when it comes to buying a suitable UTM product. It is important to establish whether you will have to pay for functionality such as email security even if you don't need it, or whether you can select only the security features you need.

Ease of deployment, configuration and management:

An SME should ensure that its IT team is well-trained and has the requisite skillsets to effectively handle the UTM appliances. A simplified unified Web interface can make advanced security features accessible to relatively unskilled staff.

Ease and speed of adding additional services:

While buying a UTM product, check if the UTM solution comes with extra security features without any additional costs like licensing fees. Else, you would have to regularly upgrade the UTM's software and firmware.

Resources of the vendor: An SME should also check how good the security research labs of the vendor are, and whether the R&D team will be able to provide new security features as updates to products already sold, as they become available elsewhere in the market. If that is not the case, the UTM will not meet your security needs in the long run.

Ability to deal with remote offices and mobile workers: Unless